An American of Indian origin, Gautam Kapur, 28, did much of his schooling in New Delhi. Here he developed his love for basketball, playing for his school team at the Siri Fort Sports Complex. He continued playing his beloved sport when he returned to the US for college, and, suddenly, he realised he was something of a novelty: a brown person, returning from a country of cricket-obsessives, passionate about basketball. "People were shocked," says Kapur, "Thinking, 'Wow, Indians can hoop?'"

Caught between two faraway lands, basketball would become the thread that tied Kapur together—and soon, help him connect with other Indian players from all over the world. "This moment of transition—from India to the US—got me dedicated to elevating basketball for all South Asians around the world."

Despite a wide diaspora of fervent basketball players, Kapur knew that 'brown ballers' like him are a rarity of sorts. Abroad, the stereotype for many Indians was to be more academic than athletic. For much of the Indian mainstream, basketball has hardly been a visible entity outside of a few scenes in Bollywood films like *Kuch Kuch Hota Hai* (1998) and an occasional big win for the national team. In a country where cricket is king, India's men's basketball team is ranked 82nd in the world. The Basketball Federation of India is known more for its dysfunction than its defence. And even though it is one of the world's most popular sports, not a single Indian player has ever played in the world's topmost basketball league, North America's National Basketball Association or NBA.

INDIA RISING WILL BE AMONG 64 TEAMS FROM AROUND THE US TO TAKE PART IN TBT—THE BASKETBALL TOURNAMENT—BROADCAST ON ESPN

Kapur was never good enough to play at a high level either, but he found his way into the NBA through the management route. After seven years of working in New York, he now serves as the league's manager of Basketball Strategy, a job that has taken him behind the scenes to the biggest stages of the game, and face to face with the finest players to ever touch the roundball.

But Kapur never forgot his dream to help elevate the game for players of Indian-origin. That opportunity has finally presented itself this year with India Rising, a media platform that he co-founded earlier this year with the mission "to unite brown ballers".

The first step in this project has been the launch of the India Rising basketball team, a collection of the best basketball players of Indian-origin from all over the world. Featuring players who have played in the NBA's official minor league (The G-League), the highest level of collegiate basketball in the US and Canada, and in leagues around the world, this assembly of talent is something that Kapur likes to call "the Avengers of brown basketball".

This month, these 'Avengers' will face their biggest opportunity yet. India Rising will be among 64 talented teams from around the US to take part in the heralded TBT—The Basketball Tournament—broadcast on ESPN, where the winners will take home a million dollars in prize money.

"I was very excited when I heard about India Rising," says Princepal Singh, 21, one of India's most successful recent prospects. "A team of all brown ballers in the TBT—that idea felt great. I want people to know that players of Indian origin can be great, that they can have good skills, and



BROWN BALLERS Kiran Shastri, Aryan Sharma, Baljyot Judge, Sukhmail Mathon